



ILLEGAL WILDLIFE TRAFFICKING GLOBAL OBSERVATORY

Weekly Monitoring Report

Cases occurring between 15 and 21 September 2026

10 cases in weekly dataset	8 countries/territories	139 animals with exact count*	1 additional record with uncertain date
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*Sum includes only cases in which the source reports a complete count of live animals. The actual total is higher because some records do not provide a complete count.

Scope. This report consolidates Observatory records whose occurrence falls within the weekly interval and revalidates the facts against open sources. Cases published this week but occurring before 15/09 were excluded from the analytical dataset.

Closing date: 21 September 2026 • Language: English • Product: Conservation Intelligence Program

1. Executive summary

For the period 15-21 September 2026, the Observatory records 10 cases with sufficient temporal information for inclusion in the weekly dataset, distributed across eight countries/territories. Seven of these records provide a complete count of live animals, totaling 139 individuals; three additional cases involve wildlife lots or products for which no complete quantity was disclosed.

The records show a diversity of methods and settings: interstate road transport, movement through a seaport, international air parcels, wildlife offered for sale through a messaging application, irregular keeping in businesses or residences, wildlife exploitation for photographs, and hunting in a protected area. The diversity of channels is more evident than any single dominant route this week.

Reptiles recur across the dataset and account for most individuals with exact counts: 30 tokay geckos in Assam, 55 Indian flapshell turtles in Odisha, and 10 turtles in a shipment from the United States to Hong Kong. Birds also appear in several contexts, including the transport of 37 wild birds from Bahia to Pernambuco and illegal wildlife offers via WhatsApp in Argentina.

Interpretation should remain cautious: origin and final destination are not established in several cases, and some sources do not yet provide full details on species, quantities, or network structure. The report therefore describes observable signals and patterns without inferring links between independent cases.

Routes and methods	Roads, airport, port, international parcel, digital trade, and local exploitation appear within the same weekly window.
Quantification rate	139 live animals have an exact reported count; other lots prevent a complete consolidated total.
Digital trade	The Angaco case (Argentina) began with cyber-patrolling and an offer of wildlife through WhatsApp.
Priority gaps	Origin/destination in Assam and Surigao; full species identification in Argentina, Hong Kong, and the Philippines; exact date of the Shenzhen case.

2. Consolidated overview

Weekly dataset: cases with sufficient temporal information for inclusion in the period. When the exact date of the act is not explicitly stated, this limitation is noted in the summary field.

Date	Country	Location	Wildlife / product	Method	Summary
16/09	Brazil	Paulo Afonso, BA	37 wild birds	Road transport	7 blue-and-yellow macaws, 2 red macaws, and 28 parrot chicks; Bahia → Pernambuco route.
16/09	Egypt	Marsa Matrouh	1 eagle + 1 lion cub	Local exploitation	Animals displayed for photographs on beaches and the promenade; seized by environmental authorities.

Date	Country	Location	Wildlife / product	Method	Summary
16/09	Guatemala	Laguna del Tigre, Petén	Wildlife meat	Hunting / possession	Two detained; rifle, shotgun, chainsaw, and meat possibly from a coati.
16-17/09	India	Malkangiri, Odisha	55 Indian flapshell turtles	Road / interstate	Four arrested; two motorcycles and four phones; sources differ by one day on the exact interception date.
17/09	India	Garmur, Golaghat, Assam	30 tokay geckos	Road transport	Joint Forest-Customs operation; one detained; origin and destination under investigation.
17/09	Argentina	Angaco, San Juan	Native birds + 1 armadillo	Digital trade	Offer detected through WhatsApp; residence searched and wildlife seized; one man detained.
17/09	Argentina	Cutral Co, Neuquén	3 African pygmy hedgehogs	Irregular trade	Commercial premises searched; firearm, ammunition, and veterinary medicines also seized.
18/09	Philippines	Port of Surigao	Cockatoos and exotic/protected tortoises	Port / transport	Two arrested; wildlife valued at ~P2.066 million; 9 mm pistol also seized; origin/destination not disclosed.
18/09	Mexico	El Bajío, Mazatlán	2 Bengal tigers	Irregular possession	Adult male and juvenile female; property lacked registration and management plan; precautionary custody.
19/09	Hong Kong	International Airport	10 live turtles	Air parcel	Parcel declared as clothing, sent from the United States; estimated value HK\$20,000.

3. Weekly analytical reading

3.1 Diversity of channels and intervention points

The ten records do not indicate a single dominant route. Instead, they show a distributed risk chain across multiple logistical and commercial points. Roads appear in Brazil and India; port and airport infrastructure appears in Surigao and Hong Kong; and digital environments appear in the San Juan case, where the investigation began after wildlife was offered through WhatsApp.

For intelligence purposes, this set supports monitoring focused on control points and transport modes, but it does not support a hypothesis of a common network across the cases. The events are treated as independent unless documentary evidence establishes links.

3.2 Taxonomic composition

Reptiles are the most numerous group among cases with exact counts: 95 individuals are distributed among the tokay geckos in Assam, the turtles in Odisha, and the turtles seized in Hong Kong. Birds are also recurrent, with 37 individuals counted in Brazil and additional presence in cases from Argentina, Egypt, and the Philippines. Mammals appear in distinct contexts: irregular trade/possession, exploitation for photographs, and keeping of exotic wildlife.

3.3 Signals for follow-up

- Assam: the investigation is still seeking the animals' origin, destination, and other people involved; this case is suitable for updating as new developments emerge.
- Surigao: the source does not disclose the total number of animals or their origin/destination; these are priority information gaps.
- Hong Kong: the international parcel, declared as clothing, provides a concrete indicator of concealment and the use of courier/parcel services.
- Argentina: the use of WhatsApp to offer wildlife reinforces the importance of cyber-patrolling as a detection mechanism, without extrapolating the scale of a network from a single case.

4. Cases during the period

01 Brazil - Paulo Afonso (BA) | 16/09/2026

Brazil's Federal Highway Police seized 37 wild birds during a stop at km 17 of BR-110. The shipment included 7 adult blue-and-yellow macaws, 2 adult red macaws, and 28 parrot chicks, kept in cardboard boxes in the cargo compartment.

The driver stated that he had been hired to transport the birds between Bahia and Pernambuco for payment. The Federal Highway Police reported that there was no environmental documentation and that transport conditions were inadequate; the animals' origin and final destination remained under investigation.

Main source: [Federal Highway Police \(Brazil\)](#)

02 Egypt - Marsa Matrouh | 16/09/2026

Environmental authorities seized an eagle and an African lion cub that were being displayed for photographs on the beaches and promenade of Marsa Matrouh. The action was conducted by the wildlife unit of the nature conservation sector in coordination with the local government.

The case is relevant because it represents direct commercial exploitation of live animals in tourism/entertainment, distinct from the transport seizures observed in other countries during the same period.

Main source: [Egyptian Environmental Affairs Agency](#)

03 Guatemala - Laguna del Tigre National Park, Petén | 16/09/2026

DIPRONA officers, in coordination with the Public Prosecutor's Office, detained two men inside Laguna del Tigre National Park. A rifle, a shotgun, a chainsaw, and a container with wild-animal meat, possibly from a coati, were seized.

The species from which the meat originated had not been confirmed in the source consulted. Authorities were investigating a possible connection between the detainees and damage to wildlife and vegetation in the protected area.

Main source: [La Hora / PNC-DIPRONA information](#)

04 India - Malkangiri, Odisha | 16-17/09/2026

A joint Forest Department and police operation intercepted 55 Indian flapshell turtles in Malkangiri. Four people were arrested; two motorcycles and four mobile phones were also seized.

Local sources agree on the shipment, location, and arrests, but differ by one day on the exact date of interception (16 or 17 September). There are indications of interstate movement between Andhra Pradesh and Odisha.

Main source: [OrissaPOST](#)

05 India - Garmur, Golaghat, Assam | 17/09/2026

Teams from the Bokakhat Range/Eastern Assam Wildlife Division and the Dimapur Customs Preventive Division seized 30 live tokay geckos (*Gekko gecko*) on NH-37. One person was detained.

Authorities opened an investigation to determine origin, destination, and possible involvement of other individuals. After legal formalities and judicial authorization, the animals were released back into the wild.

Main source: [India Today NE](#)

06 Argentina - Angaco, San Juan | 17/09/2026

San Juan Rural Police searched a residence after cyber-patrolling detected an offer of wildlife through WhatsApp. Several native birds, one armadillo, and cages were seized; one man was detained.

The investigation began on 16 September and the operation was reported on the 17th. The source does not specify the total number or species of the birds, limiting quantitative comparisons.

Main source: [San Juan Police](#)

07 Argentina - Cutral Co, Neuquén | 17/09/2026

An investigation into illegal trade in wild and exotic fauna led to a search of a commercial establishment and the seizure of three African pygmy hedgehogs. The owner was detained and the animals were placed in the custody of wildlife wardens.

A firearm, ammunition, veterinary medicines, and animal-handling items were also seized at the premises. The event is treated as an investigation into irregular trade; the source does not describe an international route associated with the animals.

Main source: [La Voz del Neuquén](#)

08 Philippines - Port of Surigao | 18/09/2026

Maritime, environmental, and port authorities intercepted a vehicle carrying exotic and protected wildlife at Gate 5 of the Port of Surigao. Groups cited included white cockatoos, red-footed tortoises, and leopard tortoises. Two representatives of a transport company were arrested.

The wildlife was valued at approximately ₱2.066 million. A 9 mm pistol was also seized. The source does not report the total number of animals or the origin or final destination of the shipment; these remain important gaps for follow-up.

Main source: [The Mindanao Sentinel](#)

09 Mexico - El Bajío, Mazatlán, Sinaloa | 18/09/2026

PROFEPA placed two Bengal tigers (*Panthera tigris*), an adult male and a juvenile female, under precautionary seizure after they were found at a property in El Bajío.

According to the authority, the site had neither SEMARNAT registration nor a management plan. The animals remained in custody at the site while the administrative procedure and final disposition were being determined.

Main source: [PROFEPA](#)

10 Hong Kong - International Airport | 19/09/2026

Hong Kong Customs seized 10 live turtles of species suspected to be protected, valued at approximately HK\$20,000. The animals were inside a box in a parcel declared as containing women's short-sleeved blouses.

The shipment had been sent from the United States to Hong Kong. The case was referred to the Agriculture, Fisheries and Conservation Department for further investigation.

Main source: [Hong Kong Customs](#)

5. Additional record published during the period, with event date not established

China - Futian Port, Shenzhen | published 18/09/2026

Huanggang Customs reported finding 20 live turtles strapped to a passenger's thighs as she entered through Futian: 19 four-toed turtles and 1 leopard tortoise. The source states that both are species listed in CITES Appendix II and that the case was referred to the anti-smuggling department.

The notice uses the term “recently” and does not provide the precise date of the interception. The case was therefore not included in the indicators for the 15-21/09 weekly dataset, although it was published and added to the monitoring flow during the week.

Main source: [The Paper / Chinese customs information](#)

6. Methodological note

Temporal criterion. The weekly dataset prioritizes the date of occurrence/seizure, not the publication date of the news item. Records published between 15 and 21 September but occurring before the reporting window were excluded from the core dataset. These include, for example, recent monitoring records from Laos (11/09), Indonesia (13-14/09), Singapore (14/09), Bolivia (11/09), Costa Rica (10/09), and Spain-Algeria (11/09).

Validation. Each case file was rechecked against accessible official or journalistic sources. Date discrepancies, incomplete quantities, and unconfirmed taxonomic identification are retained as information gaps rather than filled by inference.

Interpretation. The analytical patterns describe the set observed during this week. Similarity in method, species, or route is not treated as evidence of a link between independent cases.

7. Main sources

1. Brazil - Federal Highway Police, 17/09/2026. [Open source](#)
2. Egypt - EEAA, 16/09/2026. [Open source](#)
3. Guatemala - La Hora / PNC, 16/09/2026. [Open source](#)
4. India, Odisha - OrissaPOST, 17/09/2026. [Open source](#)
5. India, Assam - India Today NE, 20/09/2026. [Open source](#)
6. Argentina, San Juan - San Juan Police, 17/09/2026. [Open source](#)
7. Argentina, Neuquén - La Voz del Neuquén, 17/09/2026. [Open source](#)
8. Philippines - The Mindanao Sentinel, 18/09/2026. [Open source](#)
9. Mexico - PROFEPA, 18/09/2026. [Open source](#)
10. Hong Kong - Customs and Excise Department, 19/09/2026. [Open source](#)
11. China - The Paper / Huanggang Customs, 18/09/2026. [Open source](#)

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